

The Washington Post

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SU V1 V2 V3 V4



Mostly sunny 55/35 • Tomorrow: Sunny 54/35 B20

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, APRIL 7, 2026 • \$4

A new frontier for human space travel



The moon is seen in the window of NASA’s Orion spacecraft on Monday. The Artemis II crew has flown more than 248,655 miles in space, farther than any humans, surpassing the mark set by the crew of Apollo 13 in 1970. **Story, A3**

Trump renews threats as Iran rebuffs demands

VOWS RAMPAGE IN WAKE OF AIRMAN’S RESCUE

President issues Tuesday deadline for Hormuz deal

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF, SAMMY WESTFALL AND TARA COPP

President Donald Trump renewed his threat to destroy Iranian bridges and power plants if the country doesn’t soon agree to reopen the world oil trade through the Strait of Hormuz, arguing that the Iranian people supported the U.S. and Israeli bombing.

“The entire country can be taken out in one night, and that night might be tomorrow night,” he said Monday, issuing a deadline of Tuesday at 8 p.m. Eastern and pledging destruction by midnight if leaders don’t comply. The remarks came during a White House briefing where officials detailed the rescue of two U.S. airmen whose F-15E was shot down Friday

over Iran.

CIA Director John Ratcliffe and Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said Iranian officials were embarrassed by their failure to capture the U.S. aviator who was injured and stranded in rugged hostile territory for two days. Still, the Iranians showed no interest in surrendering, rejecting a U.S.-backed ceasefire proposal on Monday.

Trump at once touted the success of U.S. military operations and showed frustration with the elusive resolution to the expensive

SEE IRAN ON A10

Media threats: Trump demands to know sources, warns of jail time. **A5**

Colleges prep: U.S. schools in war zone brace for retaliations. **A11**

President: God supports U.S. cause in Iran war

BY NATALIE ALLISON

As President Donald Trump renews his threats to bomb “the entire country” of Iran, he is offering a new justification for the costly five-week conflict with no clear end in sight: God himself wants the United States to do it.

Trump said Monday that he believed God supports the United States’ actions in the U.S.-Israeli war on Iran, a widening conflict that has killed thousands in the Middle East, wounded many more, and left 13 U.S. service members dead.

“I do, because God is good,” Trump said in response to a Washington Post reporter’s question during a White House press briefing. “And God wants to see people taken care of.”

Trump’s comments mark a shift in how he is describing the war. After offering conflicting explana-

tions for U.S. involvement — including whether his goal is regime change — he has begun at times in recent days to cast the conflict in religious terms as he raises the possibility of broader strikes.

The president earlier Monday threatened to continue to bomb the country’s power and transportation infrastructure until it resembles the “stone ages.” He claimed such actions are welcomed by Iranian people who want their government overthrown, and who he said are begging the U.S. to “please keep bombing.”

Trump did not answer a question about whether he has sought God’s direction as the conflict has escalated. But he suggested that the Almighty supports U.S. action even if God is grieved by the violence.

“God doesn’t like what’s happening. I don’t like what’s happening.”

SEE WAR ON A13

Virginians are deeply divided on Spanberger

BY GREGORY S. SCHNEIDER, SCOTT CLEMENT AND PRAVEENA SOMASUNDARAM

Virginia Gov. Abigail Spanberger’s approval rating stands at 47 percent two months into the Democrat’s term, with 46 percent of voters disapproving and 7 percent expressing no opinion in a Washington Post-Schar School poll.

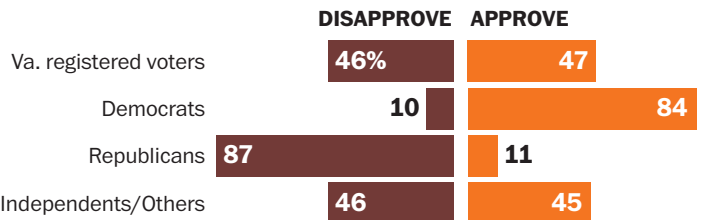
Spanberger won in a 15-point landslide last year after touting her reputation for bipartisanship built on three terms representing a conservative-leaning district in Congress. But her current ratings reflect sharp polarization among Virginia voters in their views of the state’s first female governor.

The approval mark for Spanberger is 13 percentage points lower than the average for Virgin-

Months after a landslide victory, the state’s first female governor faces sharp skepticism

Virginia voters split on Spanberger’s job performance

Q: Do you approve or disapprove of the way Abigail Spanberger is handling her job as governor of Virginia?



No opinion not shown.

Source: Washington Post-Schar School poll conducted March 26-31, 2026, among 1,101 Virginia registered voters with an error margin of +/- 3.4 percentage points. The error margin is larger among subgroups.

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ia governors in Post polling since the 1990s. Her near-even split between approval and disapproval is a worse net approval rating than the early-term scores of her predecessors in previous Post polls. It is also slightly weaker than ratings of her immediate predecessor, Glenn Youngkin (R), in a Post-Schar School poll last fall, showing he ended his term with 50 percent approval and 46 percent disapproval. Unlike Spanberger, Youngkin had come into office with a very narrow victory.

In a positive sign for Spanberger, elements of her affordability agenda score well with voters, suggesting room to improve her image after a rocky start. The governor also continues to be more popular than President Donald Trump among Virginia

SEE SPANBERGER ON A4

Conservative-touted college entrance exam gains traction

More states are adopting Classic Learning Test despite critics’ concerns

BY TODD WALLACK

An upstart college entrance exam — designed to be an alternative to the ACT and SAT and featuring works from ancient Western civilization — is gaining support from the Trump administration and conservatives in red and purple states.

In recent months, the Pentagon decided to accept the Classic Learning Test for U.S. military service academies and scholarships at other colleges around the country. Indiana enacted legislation in March requiring its state universities to consider CLT scores, along with those from the SAT and ACT. And the North Carolina university system agreed to take the CLT, including at its

flagship campus in Chapel Hill.

“We’ve had some big wins,” said Jeremy Tate, founder of the test and the Maryland company behind it, Classic Learning Initiatives.

While all three tests have verbal and math sections, the CLT stands out because it mainly features passages from noted philosophers, religious scholars, scientists and authors in the canon of Western literature, including Plato, St. Augustine, Dante and Shakespeare. Students can take the test at a traditional testing site or online at home.

Since its creation in 2015, the CLT has been embraced by many Christian schools, home schooling families and educators in the classical education movement who want children to study foundational texts that they say helped shape American history and culture.

But the exam’s growing popularity has sparked questions

SEE TEST ON A2



MAXINE WALLACE/TH THE WASHINGTON POST

Tradition rolls along

President Donald Trump delivers remarks with first lady Melania Trump and the Easter Bunny on Monday as the annual White House Easter Egg Roll takes place on the South Lawn. **Style, B1**

In secrecy, a U.S.-centric global health plan develops

BY ADAM TAYLOR

The Trump administration has spent the better part of a year quietly negotiating agreements with poorer nations as it seeks to scale back and reimagine U.S. foreign assistance for efforts like HIV and tuberculosis prevention through a new “America First” global health strategy.

To date, 28 deals have been negotiated with foreign governments, mostly throughout Africa. But in a break with precedent, the administration has refused to disclose their full terms publicly.

The veil of secrecy has frustrated partner countries and angered transparency advocates, who worry that billions of dollars in U.S. funding — money intended to help combat disease — is

SEE HEALTH ON A12

IN THE NEWS

Protections lost The Trump administration is ending civil rights settlements that aimed to protect trans students from discrimination. **A4**

ICE actions in DMV Agents made nearly 20,000 arrests in the region from the start of President Donald Trump’s second term through March 10, federal data shows. **B12**

THE NATION The Supreme Court cleared a path for Stephen K. Bannon, President Trump’s former chief strategist, in his effort to have his Jan. 6 conviction overturned. **A5**

THE WORLD Residents of sleep Khasab, Oman, have a waterfront view of the fight over the Strait of Hormuz. **A9**

China stands to gain the most from the war-driven energy crisis. **A14**

THE ECONOMY Trump risks shaking the confidence in the U.S. as a guardian of global shipping, if he pulls out of the Middle East too soon. **A15**

Sewers, dressmakers and tailors are aging out of the workforce, even as demands for their skills grow. **A16**

STYLE A glittering mess of a TV show that understood the assignment: “The Real Housewives of Rhode Island.” **B1**

SPORTS The Mystics fired GM Jamila Wideman on the opening day of free agency in the WNBA. **B7**

THE REGION An elevator door severed a woman’s arm in a historic D.C. building. Video shows how quickly the horror happened. **B12**

A Virginia church pledges \$1M to help public housing residents pay off their outstanding balances. **B12**

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COMICS.....B4
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